

Kitchen & *Kettle*

Natural Homekeeping Guide

FEWER PRODUCTS. BETTER SYSTEMS.

Cleaning recipes from kitchen
ingredients, simple routine
templates, and honest guidance on
what works — without the fear-
mongering or perfectionism.

You don't need a different product for every surface.

Why fewer products?

Most of what a house needs for cleaning can be handled with three things: soap, an acid, and a mild abrasive. The rest is knowing when to use each one — and when to admit a commercial product does the job better.

This isn't about avoiding "chemicals." Everything is chemicals. Water is a chemical. This is about reducing the number of bottles under your sink, understanding what's actually in them, and spending less money on things you don't need.

The seven-ingredient cleaning pantry

White vinegar

A mild acid. Dissolves mineral deposits, cuts grease, deodorizes.

Glass, counters, bathroom surfaces, laundry rinse, coffee maker descaling.

HONEST NOTE

Does not disinfect. Does not kill most bacteria effectively. Use it for cleaning (removing dirt and residue), not sanitizing. If someone in the house is sick, use something stronger.

Baking soda

A mild abrasive and deodorizer. Scrubs without scratching most surfaces.

Sinks, tubs, stovetops, oven, deodorizing fridge and drains, laundry booster.

HONEST NOTE

The baking soda + vinegar fizz is not what cleans — it's just the two neutralizing each other into salt water and CO₂. Use them separately: scrub with baking soda, rinse, then wipe with vinegar. Combining them at the same time wastes both.

Castile soap (liquid) or plain bar soap

A true soap made from plant oils or gentle fats. Cuts through dirt and grease. Liquid castile is convenient; a plain bar like Ivory or Dove Sensitive works just as well — grate it and dissolve in warm water for a liquid version, or rub a damp cloth directly on the bar.

All-purpose spray, dish soap, hand soap, floor cleaner, laundry (in soft water).

HONEST NOTE

Castile soap can be irritating to some people's skin. If it bothers you, switch to a plain unscented bar soap (Ivory, Dove Sensitive, or similar). They clean just as well and many people find them gentler. Also: don't mix any soap with vinegar — they cancel each other out and leave a gross residue.

Citric acid

A stronger, odorless acid alternative to vinegar. Excellent descaler.

Dishwasher cleaner, washing machine cleaner, kettle descaling, bathroom fixtures.

Salt (coarse)

Abrasive and absorbent. Good for scrubbing stubborn residue.

Cast iron cleaning, cutting board scrubbing, oven spill absorption, red wine stain removal.

Hydrogen peroxide (3%)

An oxidizing cleaner and mild disinfectant.

Stain removal (blood, fruit), cutting board sanitizing, grout whitening, laundry brightener.

HONEST NOTE

Breaks down in light — keep it in the dark bottle it came in. Don't mix with vinegar (creates peracetic acid — irritant).

Isopropyl alcohol (70% or 50%)

Fast-evaporating solvent. Cuts grease and leaves zero streaks.

Glass and mirror cleaner, disinfecting, removing sticky residue, DIY hand sanitizer.

HONEST NOTE

Makes a better glass cleaner than vinegar — faster drying, no streaks, cuts through fingerprints. If all you have is vinegar, it works too, but alcohol is the upgrade worth keeping under the sink.

WHEN TO USE COMMERCIAL PRODUCTS

Toilet bowl cleaner (the commercial stuff works better than anything DIY), laundry detergent in hard water, dishwasher detergent, and anything labeled "disinfectant" when someone in the house is sick. This isn't absolutism. Use what works.

Cleaning Recipes

All of these use the six ingredients on the previous page. Nothing exotic. Nothing you'll use once and abandon.

All-Purpose Spray

For: counters, tables, sinks, most hard surfaces. Daily use.

1 cup water • 1 cup white vinegar • optional: 10 drops essential oil (lemon, tea tree, or lavender)

1. Combine in a spray bottle. Shake before each use.
2. Spray surface. Wipe with a clean cloth.

Do not use on: marble, granite, natural stone (acid etches these). Use plain water and a drop of liquid soap or a damp cloth rubbed on a bar of mild soap for stone.

Soft Scrub (sinks, tubs, stovetops)

For: porcelain, stainless steel, enamel, ceramic.

Baking soda • liquid soap or a plain bar (castile, Ivory, or Dove Sensitive) • water

1. Sprinkle baking soda onto the wet surface.
2. Add a few drops of liquid soap, or rub a damp cloth on a bar of mild soap.
3. Scrub with a damp cloth or sponge. Rinse thoroughly.

Glass & Mirror Cleaner

For: windows, mirrors, glass tabletops.

½ cup isopropyl alcohol (70% or 50%) • ½ cup water • spray bottle

1. Combine in a spray bottle. Shake gently — no need to shake every time, it stays mixed.
2. Spray onto glass. Wipe with a microfiber cloth or crumpled newspaper.

Alcohol evaporates faster than vinegar, cuts through grease and fingerprints, and leaves zero streaks. If you don't have alcohol, ¼ cup white vinegar + 1 cup water + 1 tsp cornstarch works too — just shake before each use.

Floor Cleaner

For: sealed hardwood, tile, laminate, linoleum.

1 gallon hot water • ¼ cup white vinegar • 2–3 drops mild liquid soap (optional, for extra cleaning)

1. Combine in a bucket. Mop as usual.
2. No need to rinse — vinegar residue evaporates.

Oven Cleaner (non-toxic, requires elbow grease)

For: oven interiors. Overnight method.

Baking soda • water • white vinegar (for final wipe)

1. Make a paste of baking soda and water. Spread over oven surfaces, avoiding heating elements.
2. Let sit overnight (at least 8 hours).
3. Scrub with a damp cloth or sponge. Spray vinegar on stubborn spots to help lift residue.
4. Wipe clean with water.

HONEST NOTE

This works but it's work. If your oven is truly terrible, a commercial oven cleaner is faster. Use the DIY method for maintenance cleaning; use the heavy stuff for the once-a-year deep clean.

Drain Cleaner (preventative)

For: slow drains, deodorizing.

½ cup baking soda • boiling water • ½ cup white vinegar (optional, for odor)

1. Pour baking soda down the drain. Follow with a kettle of boiling water to flush it through.
2. If the drain smells, follow with vinegar after the hot water has drained — but don't mix them at the same time. The fizzing reaction is just baking soda and vinegar neutralizing each other. It doesn't clean anything. Use them separately.

This maintains drains. It will not clear a full clog—for that, use a plunger, a drain snake, or call someone.

Cleaning Rhythms

A rhythm is not a schedule. If you miss a day, pick up where you left off. If you only have 10 minutes, do the thing that bothers you most. The goal is a home that stays functional, not a home that's always clean.

DAILY (5–15 MINUTES)

- ☐ Make the bed (or just straighten covers — honestly, close enough)
- ☐ Wipe kitchen counters after dinner
- ☐ Wash dishes or load dishwasher (run it if full)
- ☐ Quick sweep of kitchen floor (the crumb zone)
- ☐ Put away 5 things that aren't where they belong

WEEKLY (DO ON WHATEVER DAY YOU HAVE ENERGY)

- ☐ Clean bathroom: mirror, counter, sink, toilet, quick shower spray
- ☐ Change towels and kitchen cloths
- ☐ Vacuum or sweep all floors
- ☐ Mop kitchen and bathroom floors
- ☐ Take out trash and recycling
- ☐ Wipe down kitchen appliances (outside)
- ☐ One load of laundry, start to finish (including putting it away)

MONTHLY

- ☐ Clean inside microwave
- ☐ Wipe cabinet fronts and handles
- ☐ Clean washing machine (run empty with vinegar or citric acid)
- ☐ Dust surfaces you usually ignore (baseboards, light fixtures, ceiling corners)
- ☐ Check and toss expired fridge items
- ☐ Wash one item you usually don't: shower curtain, bath mat, throw pillow covers

IF YOU ONLY DO ONE THING

A clean kitchen and a clean bathroom make a house feel functional. If you're overwhelmed, skip everything else. Do those two. You'll feel better.

Laundry & Simple Care

LAUNDRY THAT LASTS

- **Cold water for most things.** Hot water sets stains, fades colors, and wears out elastic. Use warm for towels and bedding; hot for truly soiled items.
- **Less detergent than the bottle says.** The manufacturer wants you to use more so you buy more. Start with half. Increase only if things aren't getting clean.
- **Air dry when you can.** The dryer is the hardest thing you do to your clothes. Hang or lay flat anything you want to keep for years.
- **Don't overwash.** Jeans, sweaters, and outer layers don't need washing after every wear. Hang them to air out between uses.

COMMERCIAL VS. DIY LAUNDRY DETERGENT

People swear by homemade laundry detergent (grated soap + washing soda + borax). In soft water, it works okay. In hard water, it builds up on clothes and in your machine. If you have hard water, use a good commercial detergent — it's genuinely better for your clothes and your washing machine.

STAIN REMOVAL THAT WORKS

STAIN	WHAT TO USE	METHOD
Blood	Cold water + hydrogen peroxide	Rinse in cold water immediately. Dab peroxide on remaining stain. Never hot water — it cooks the protein and sets the stain.
Red wine	Salt, then cold water	Cover fresh stain with salt to absorb liquid. Rinse with cold water. Launder normally.
Grease / oil	Dish soap or baking soda	Rub a drop of dish soap into the stain. Or cover with baking soda to absorb oil, brush off, then wash.
Coffee / tea	Cold water, vinegar if needed	Rinse immediately with cold water. Dab vinegar on stubborn spots. Launder.
Tomato / berry	Cold water, then sunlight	Rinse, rub with a little detergent, and lay in direct sun. UV breaks down the pigments. Works surprisingly well.
Sweat / deodorant	White vinegar soak	Soak the stained area in vinegar for 30 minutes before washing. Prevents yellowing over time.

A note on homekeeping

A clean house is not a moral achievement. A messy house is not a personal failure. These are just systems for making a space that supports your life instead of draining your energy.

Some weeks the house will be clean. Some weeks it won't. Both weeks, you still deserve to rest in it.

If you try one thing from this guide, make it the all-purpose spray. It takes thirty seconds to mix, costs almost nothing, and replaces the three different surface cleaners you probably have under the sink. That's one less thing to buy, store, and think about. That's the whole philosophy.

CLEANING RHYTHM THAT WORKS FOR ME	PRODUCTS I STOPPED BUYING
THINGS I STILL BUY (AND WHY)	SEASONAL CLEANING NOTES

Kitchen & Kettle • Works because it works.
Fewer products. Better systems. Less to think about.